

Emmy Schulz

Gregory Winter

Film 200

05/23/2025

The Oscar Was Well Deserved

Although I have heard of the film for many years, this was my first time viewing it. And I truly have never seen anything like it. Watching *Moonlight*, I was immediately hooked by the emotional depth that the director Barry Jenkins brings to the screen. The film is rare. It explores the intersections of identity, masculinity, race, and sexuality through the life of Chiron, while also resisting traditional narratives. Told in three distinct chapters- childhood, adolescence, and adulthood. One of my favorite scenes is striking because Juan, a drug dealer, becomes a father figure to Chiron and teaches him how to swim. As someone whose father passed when I was extremely young, I have plenty of “father figures” who stepped in to teach me how to swim literally and figuratively. So, watching this scene, I felt as if I understood what this moment meant. But beyond my resonance, this scene is a masterclass in film technique. The swim lesson scene in *Moonlight* marks a transformative moment in Chiron’s journey to self-identity. Using intimate camera work, lighting, and sound, the scene evokes emotional depth and establishes the ocean as a space of connection and peace for Chiron.

The camera work and cinematography in the swim lesson scene are essential in drawing viewers into Chiron’s emotional world. Jenkins worked with cinematographer James Laxton to craft the visual narrative. They used a handheld camera that was able to be used in the water, which allowed the scene to feature heavy close-ups and point-of-view shots. The camera floats on the waves alongside Juan and Chiron, mirroring the physical movement of the water, and

places the audience within the vulnerable moment. When Juan holds Chiron in the water and encourages him to relax, the camera stays on Chiron's face as he fights both fear and curiosity. These close-up shots are key, as they allow the audience to witness shifts in expressions, emphasizing Chiron's internal struggle and acceptance of Juan's guidance. The use of the handheld camera also contributes to a sense of an organic moment. It doesn't feel staged or composed, it feels real. The camera's physical closeness to Juan and Chiron reflects the emotional closeness developing between them, and when Juan supports Chiron in the water, the camera goes closer, which eliminates any emotional distance between the characters and the audience. This visual intimacy is key to understanding the scene's significance. Which is for the first time, Chiron is touched with care, spoken to with patience, and held with security. Through this approach, Jenkins makes the audience a participant in the moment, reinforcing the idea that this connection is not only meaningful to Chiron but essential to his development.

The lighting in the swim scene reinforces the emotional intimacy between Juan and Chiron. Filled with natural light, filming under the sun creates warm tones on their skin. Compared to other scenes filled with darkness, shadows, and artificial lighting, such as Chiron's neighborhood and inside his home. The sunlight reflects off the water and surrounds them, almost like a spotlight, making them seem as if they're in the middle of the world.

"Right there, you in the middle of the world, man." (Juan states in the scene)

The visual serenity mirrors the emotional sanctuary that Juan is providing to Chiron. The ocean, which is known to be uncontrollable, was calm under Jenkins' lens. It's no accident that the sun is at its softest when Juan cradles Chiron in the water, guiding him through the waves. I believe the interplay of light and water is replicating a baptism. Chiron is not simply being taught "how to swim," he is experiencing a transformation. Lighting is helping build the ocean's

identity as a symbolic space for Chiron, somewhere that exists outside of the harshness of his daily life. We see this when he revisits the ocean later in the film. Jenkins positions the ocean as a site of rebirth, and the natural light is a metaphor for purity and peace. This is not a swim lesson, it is a visual awakening.

The scene would not be the same without the sound design; each choice of sound is subtle yet supports the film's emotional and symbolic depth. It is layered with natural sounds, such as the waves, the splashing of Chiron swimming, and breathing. Then, in the background, is an orchestra slowly building to help the audience feel more. The music is gentle, and it doesn't overpower the scene; in my mind, it is a cue to the audience that something is shifting internally. Juan's minimal dialogue is full of encouraging and calming words: "Let your head rest in my hand, relax, I've got you, I promise. I'm not gonna let you go, hey man, I got you." They are powerful and contribute to the environment that is being created. One might argue that less is more. If a scene is too busy, the audience's emotion isn't allowed to rise organically, I do agree with this. But Jenkins did this perfectly, the sounds fit together seamlessly. Chiron's vulnerability is shown in the way his breathing is amplified, and in contrast, Juan's calm, steady voice provides an anchor. We are being shown how significant this small gesture of care is to a boy who rarely experiences it. Jenkins uses sound to emphasize that Chiron is finally allowed to be held in caring arms and be a kid.

The ocean in *Moonlight* is more than just a setting. It is a powerful symbol of possibility. From the moment Juan teaches Chiron how to swim, the ocean becomes a place where different rules apply compared to other settings in the film. It is a place of softness, healing and transformation. His school is a site of bullying and violence, his home is scarred with emotional

neglect and addiction. The ocean is quiet and open. Jenkins repeatedly uses it as a visual and thematic counterpoint to Chiron feeling inferior in his own mind and in the world

“At some point, you gotta decide for yourself who you’re going to be- can’t let nobody make that decision for you.”

In the end of the scene, Juan shared a story of the nickname “Blue”, about when he was a child with no direction. This story shows a central theme of the film: self-determination in the face of rigid societal expectations. In this quote, he is sharing that he decided to find his way, and search for his own identity. Now he is helping guide Chiron, and I think it’s because he sees himself in him. Jenkins is using the ocean to show where black masculinity is reimagined. Juan, a drug dealer, is one of the few men who treat Chiron gently. He guides him into the water with care and reassurance, not with orders or demands. Floating in the waves, Chiron is both literally and figuratively supported. In the moment, Jenkins is presenting an alternative model of masculinity rooted not in dominance or violence, but in emotional generosity and trust. Juan is an example of how *you can decide for yourself who you want to be*, despite the societal norm in this film. The use of the ocean helps rewrite traditional cinematic tropes that often associate Black male characters with aggression. Instead, Chiron’s journey into the water becomes a visual metaphor for a deeper emotional journey towards vulnerability and self-discovery.

The swim lesson scene in *Moonlight* is far more than a moment of connection between two characters, it is a cinematic statement about identity, vulnerability and the quiet power of human connection. Through his use of intimate camera work, natural lighting, and subtle sound design, Barry Jenkins creates a transformative moment in Chiron’s journey to self-identity. Offering the viewer insight into how acts of care can be deeply formative. What makes the scene so powerful is its stillness. There is no conflict, no drama, and no resolution. Instead, the focus is

on presence. The presence of another person who cares, the presence of touch without harm, and the presence of an environment that nurtures rather than threatens. The ocean, as a recurring symbol, holds all of this. The ocean is a different world where Chiron can let go of trying to act tough and simply float and swim. *Moonlight* challenges viewers to reconsider what it means to come of age in a world that offers few safe spaces for vulnerability. The swim scene may not be a large plot turning scene, but it sure is an emotional and symbolic one. Chiron's inner world is opening for his identity to be shaped. This film offers a different kind of hero's journey, not one of conquest, but of emotional awakening. The swim scene embodies this journey; it's a single moment where a boy begins to believe that he is not alone and that he matters. Jenkins doesn't show a coming-of-age story, he redefines what it means to grow and heal.

Sources

Coggan, Devan. ““Moonlight” Director Barry Jenkins Breaks down the Film’s Key Swim Lesson Scene.” *EW.com*, 6 Dec. 2016, ew.com/article/2016/12/06/moonlight-barry-jenkins-swimming-lesson-scene/.

Gilbert, Sophie. “Revisiting the Symbolism of Water in Barry Jenkins’s “Moonlight.”” *The Atlantic*, The Atlantic, 26 Dec. 2016, www.theatlantic.com/entertainment/archive/2016/12/the-power-of-water-in-moonlight/511547/.

Salik Waquas. “Cinematography Analysis of Moonlight (in Depth) - Color Culture.” *Color Culture*, 29 Nov. 2024, colorculture.org/cinematography-analysis-of-moonlight-in-depth/.

“What I like About: Moonlight and the Metaphor of Water.” *You Call Yourself a Film Critic*, 10 June 2019, youcallyourselfafilmcritic.wordpress.com/2019/06/10/what-i-like-about-moonlight-and-the-metaphor-of-water/.

Works Cited

AuthorLastName, FirstName. *Title of the Book Being Referenced*. City Name: Name of

Publisher, Year. Type of Medium (e.g. Print).

LastName, First, Middle. "Article Title." *Journal Title* (Year): Pages From - To. Print.